

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

WAR OVER HISTORY

A fierce battle is going on between Union law minister Kiren Rijiju and Congress communication in-charge and Rajya Sabha MP Jairam Ramesh over Jawaharlal Nehru's role in Jammu and Kashmir and Arunachal Pradesh's inclusion in India. On October 27, Rijiju claimed that while Maharaja Hari Singh, the then ruler of Kashmir, wanted to join India, Nehru was initially reluctant. Congress leader and Hari Singh's son Karan Singh, too, claimed that his father was not to be blamed for the delay in J&K's accession. Four days later, Rijiju fired another salvo saying Nehru was upset with the inclusion of Tawang in India. In response, Ramesh produced several documents, including Nehru's telegrams, asserting that Rijiju had been "peddling lies". He even coined a new term for him—distorian. The favour awaits a return.

CONSPICUOUS ABSENCE

The social awkwardness between **Himanta Biswa Sarma** and **Sarbananda Sonowal** is evident in public now. Sarma had unseated Sonowal as the Assam chief minister in May 2021, and the latter was awarded a berth in the Union cabinet. Though both leaders have been extremely gracious to each other, of late they are trying to maintain a social distance. On November 3, Sarma participated in the 75th anniversary of the Assam Medical College, located in Sonowal's hometown Dibrugarh. While the Union minister was in Assam that day, he gave the event a miss despite an invite, and chose to attend the premiere of an Assamese film instead.



BANDEEP SINGH

YASIR IQBAL

Owaisi's Revenge



With the Rashtriya Janata Dal narrowly losing the Gopalganj seat in Lalu Prasad's home town, among the WhatsApp messages circulating in Patna was one about *Owaisi ka badla*. In November 2020, when the Tejashwi Yadav-led grand alliance fell short of a simple majority, they had pinned the blame on **Asaduddin Owaisi**'s AIMIM (All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) winning the five minority-dominated seats. In June 2022, Lalu's son settled the score by poaching four of the five AIMIM legislators in Bihar, regaining the single-largest party status for the RJD. Now, four months later, Owaisi's party seems to have got its own back, when the AIMIM candidate bagged more than 12,000 votes in Gopalganj, ensuring the BJP's victory over the RJD by less than 2,000 votes.



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All in the Family

The two factions of Apna Dal–Apna Dal (S) headed by Union Minister **Anupriya Patel** and Apna Dal (K) led by her mother Krishna Patel–are engaged in an intense social media war. At the party's recent convention in Lucknow, Anupriya's husband and Apna Dal (S) convenor Ashish Patel, who also happens to be a minister in Uttar Pradesh, sought to call a truce. He asked party workers to not engage in negative social media posts. Anupriya also said she would keep fighting for social justice, irrespective of the challenges, including from her "own people". The couple certainly doesn't want the family feud to hijack the political narrative.

GOODWILL HUNTING

When Manipur governor La. Ganesan, who now holds additional charge of West Bengal, invited Chief Minister **Mamata Banerjee** to his elder brother's 80th birthday celebrations in Chennai, she promptly agreed. A two-day visit to the city also gave the Trinamool Congress chief the welcome opportunity to break bread with her Tamil Nadu counterpart M.K. Stalin and his sister Kanimozhi. Didi seems to be tapping the southern states for an anti-BJP alliance as northern leaders such as Delhi chief minister and AAP convenor Arvind Kejriwal and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav have shown little interest. Will her southern sojourn yield results?



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Kaushik Deka *with* ***Romita Datta, Prashant Srivastava and Amitabh Srivastava***